ONLINE ADVANCES

DATING APPS, ROBOTS AND AI: TECHNOLOGY HAVE TRANSFORMED THE WAY INDIANS THINK ABOUT AND ENGAGE WITH SEX

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Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**

THERE WAS A TIME WHEN DHRUV SHARMA (NAME CHANGED), A 19-YEAR-OLD STUDENT from Pune, would shudder at the thought of asking someone out. Engaging women or trying to develop sexual intimacy was a daunting task, one not made easy by his body image issues. But that's all in the past now, thanks to technology and the internet, where, Sharma says, he is free of such physical hang-ups and can have consensual virtual sex. "It is empowering. I have four-five partners on various apps. We use video chats that are non-encrypted.... It has helped me feel better about my body and I can now even meet women offline without feeling ashamed of myself," he says.

Thousands of Indian youths like Sharma have in recent years embraced the idea of finding sexual or emotional intimacy virtually. India emerged as the fifth-largest growing market in terms of year-over-year growth in dating app spending in 2022, according to data.ai Intelligence, a platform that brings together consumer data and market insights. In fact, Indians spent $31 million more on dating apps last year than they did in 2021. That is not all, technological advances also mean that more Indians are focusing on their sexual wellness and pleasure. According to sex toy analysis firm ThatsPersonal.com, there was a 54 per cent rise in Google searches for sex toys by